March 7

George Shultz and I met. Our plans about the Soviet Union are going forward. He is giving Ambassador Dobrynin my letter for delivery to Chernenko.

In the letter to Chernenko, I said I believed it would be advantageous for us to communicate directly and confidentially. I tried to use the old actor's technique of empathy: to imagine the world as seen through another's eyes and try to help my audience see it through my eyes. "I fully appreciate the priority you attach to the security of the Soviet state," I wrote, "particularly in light of the enormous costs shouldered by your people in helping to defeat Nazi Germany." I said it was my understanding that some people in the Soviet Union felt a genuine fear of our country.

"But I cannot understand why our programs can be considered threatening," I wrote. Since 1970, the letter went on, the USSR had developed three new intercontinental ballistic missiles, five new submarine-launched ballistic missiles, and thirteen modernized versions of other Soviet missiles. Yes, we had begun to develop new weapons systems after a long period, but only in response to the Soviet buildup.

As we see it, you claim to be responding to the U.S. program. Yet your new missiles have been deployed years ahead of their U.S. counterparts, not to mention in greater numbers . . . I recognize that neither of us will be able to persuade the other as to who is to blame for the poor state of our relations, nor would it be productive for the two of us to engage in a lengthy debate on the subject. I doubt, however, that we can make progress in reducing the high levels of armaments if either of us is unwilling to take into account the concerns of the other.